FRANCES & KEVIN

MARKETING MANAGER TO MARKETING DIRECTOR

THE STRATEGIC LEADERSHIP PLAYBOOK

A working guide for marketers who want to make better commercial decisions, lead with more authority and build credible evidence for the next role.

7
director-level capabilities

1
board-ready planning framework

90
day development plan

START HERE

USE THIS AS A WORKING DOCUMENT

This playbook is designed to be written on, challenged and revisited. Use examples from your current role rather than hypothetical answers. The aim is to leave with stronger evidence of how you think and lead, not simply a list of things you already know.

THE OUTCOME

By the end, you should have a clearer view of the gaps that matter, the evidence you already have, and the specific actions that will strengthen your case for broader marketing leadership.

THREE WAYS TO GET VALUE FROM IT

01

Be specific

Use real budgets, real stakeholders and real commercial problems. General answers will not tell you much.

02

Look for evidence

Confidence matters, but senior progression is easier when you can point to decisions, outcomes and influence.

03

Revisit it

Score yourself again in 90 days. The question is not whether you feel more senior. It is whether your evidence has improved.

ASSESS

01 YOUR LEADERSHIP BASELINE

Score each statement from 1 (rarely true) to 5 (consistently true). Treat the lowest scores as a practical development agenda.

AREA	WHAT TO TEST	SCORE
Commercial thinking	I can connect marketing activity to revenue, margin, pipeline, retention or another business measure.	____
Strategic judgement	I can explain what we should stop doing as clearly as what we should start.	____
Leadership	I set direction and standards without needing to control every task.	____
Influence	I can challenge senior stakeholders constructively and still keep them with me.	____
Data	I can turn performance data into a recommendation, not just a report.	____
Brand and customer	I can balance short-term demand with long-term brand and customer value.	____
Financial confidence	I can build, defend and reallocate a marketing budget.	____
Career evidence	I can show examples of operating beyond my formal job description.	____

READING YOUR SCORE

32-40: strong evidence of director-level behaviour. 24-31: close, with a few gaps to strengthen. Under 24: build more evidence before making the title the main objective.

02 CHANGE THE LEVEL OF THE QUESTION

The move into senior marketing is less about doing more and more about deciding what matters.

Marketing Managers are often rewarded for getting work delivered. Marketing Directors are judged on judgement: where to invest, what to stop, how marketing affects the commercial plan, how teams perform and whether senior stakeholders trust the function.

CHANNELS CHOICES

Start with the business problem, the audience and the proposition. Channels come later.

ACTIVITY ECONOMICS

Know what growth is worth, what the business can afford to pay and where conversion is being lost.

CERTAINTY JUDGEMENT

Senior roles involve incomplete information. State the assumptions, make the call and manage the downside.

HEROICS SYSTEMS

If everything depends on you, the function is fragile. Build owners, rhythms, standards and clear briefs.

MARKETING LANGUAGE BOARD LANGUAGE

Translate clicks, reach and engagement into revenue, cost, risk, customer behaviour and competitive advantage.

BUILD

03 SEVEN CAPABILITIES WORTH BUILDING

These are the areas that tend to separate strong delivery managers from credible functional leaders.

01 Commercial fluency

Understand the business model, revenue targets, margin pressure and what sales needs from marketing.

02 Strategy

Turn diagnosis into a small number of choices. A strategy should make priorities and trade-offs obvious.

03 Leadership

Set standards, coach people, handle underperformance and create the conditions for good work.

04 Stakeholder influence

Work effectively with founders, finance, sales, operations and agencies without slipping into marketing jargon.

05 Measurement

Choose metrics that change decisions. Separate genuine signal from reporting noise.

06 Brand judgement

Protect long-term distinctiveness while still delivering short-term demand.

07 Operating rhythm

Create a cadence for priorities, budgets, reviews, decisions and learning.

TURN GAPS INTO EVIDENCE

For each capability, write down one example where you have already demonstrated it. If you cannot find one, create the opportunity in your current role during the next 90 days.

COMMERCIAL

04 BUILD A COMMERCIAL MARKETING STORY

You do not need to become an accountant. You do need to understand how the business makes money and how marketing changes that picture.

YOUR FIVE-NUMBER DASHBOARD

- Revenue or qualified pipeline influenced by marketing.
- Cost to acquire a customer, learner, lead or opportunity.
- Conversion rate at the most commercially important stage.
- Retention, repeat purchase or customer value where relevant.
- Marketing investment against the outcome it is expected to create.

THE BOARD-READY SENTENCE

Practise turning a performance update into one clear line: “We invested £X, generated Y, the constraint is Z, and I recommend A next because…”

WRITE YOUR VERSION

05 THE ONE-PAGE STRATEGIC MARKETING PLAN

Senior teams rarely need a 40-slide plan. They need enough clarity to understand the choices, the logic and the decisions required.

1. BUSINESS OBJECTIVE

What commercial outcome matters most?

2. DIAGNOSIS

What is actually stopping that outcome today?

3. PRIORITY AUDIENCE

Who matters most, and what needs to change in their behaviour?

4. PROPOSITION

Why should they choose us? What is the proof?

5. STRATEGIC CHOICES

What two or three things will we prioritise? What will we deliberately not do?

6. MEASURES

Which numbers will tell us whether the strategy is working?

7. DECISIONS NEEDED

What budget, people, technology or stakeholder decisions are required?

INFLUENCE

06 LEAD BEYOND THE MARKETING TEAM

Director-level performance is often decided outside marketing. The quality of your relationships with sales, finance, operations and the CEO matters as much as technical marketing knowledge.

STAKEHOLDER	WHAT THEY CARE ABOUT	WHAT THEY NEED FROM MARKETING	NEXT CONVERSATION
CEO / MD			
Sales			
Finance			
Operations / Delivery			
Product / Service			

BEFORE THE MEETING

Ask yourself: what does this person need to believe, what evidence will matter to them, what objection are they likely to raise, and what decision am I actually asking for?

LEAD

07 STOP BEING THE BOTTLENECK

Being the person who can fix everything may have helped you progress. At director level, the same habit can hold the team back.

PRIORITIES

Everyone knows the few things that matter this quarter.

OWNERSHIP

Every important outcome has one accountable owner.

STANDARDS

The definition of good work is clear before the review.

CADENCE

Weekly priorities, monthly performance, quarterly strategy.

DELEGATION DIAGNOSTIC

List three things you still personally own that somebody else could learn to own with a better brief, sensible guardrails and regular feedback.

A BETTER QUESTION

Replace “How can I get this done?” with “What would make this easier for somebody else to own well?”

PROVE

08 BUILD EVIDENCE BEFORE THE TITLE

Do not wait for a Marketing Director vacancy to start operating at the next level. Use your current role to build visible proof.

FIVE PROOF POINTS TO BUILD

- A commercial decision you influenced.
- A budget you improved, protected or reallocated.
- A team or person whose performance improved because of your leadership.
- A strategic choice where you stopped low-value activity.
- A cross-functional problem you helped solve.

TURN ONE INTO A LEADERSHIP CASE STUDY

SITUATION	What was happening?
DIAGNOSIS	What did you believe the real issue was?
DECISION	What did you choose, and why?
INFLUENCE	Who did you need to bring with you?
OUTCOME	What changed commercially or organisationally?
LEARNING	What would you do differently next time?

ACT

09 YOUR 90-DAY ACCELERATION PLAN

The quickest route to greater confidence is stronger evidence. Use the next three months deliberately.

DAYS 1-30

DIAGNOSE

- Score your leadership gaps
- Learn the business numbers
- Meet key stakeholders
- Identify one strategic problem
- Stop one low-value activity

DAYS 31-60

LEAD

- Own one cross-functional issue
- Delegate one recurring task
- Build a one-page strategy
- Present a commercial recommendation
- Coach someone in your team

DAYS 61-90

PROVE

- Capture measurable outcomes
- Update your CV and LinkedIn with leadership evidence
- Ask a senior leader for feedback
- Build a portfolio case study
- Decide your next career move

MY 90-DAY COMMITMENT

TALK

10 FIVE CONVERSATIONS THAT MOVE CAREERS

Senior progression often comes from better conversations. Put these in the diary rather than waiting for the right moment.

YOUR MANAGER	“What would you need to see from me to trust me with broader commercial responsibility?”
SALES	“Where does marketing currently make your job harder, and where could it create more leverage?”
FINANCE	“Which marketing numbers would make budget decisions easier for you?”
CEO / MD	“What is the biggest commercial risk or growth constraint you think marketing could influence?”
YOUR TEAM	“What am I doing today that stops you taking more ownership?”

BOARD UPDATE STRUCTURE

1. Outcome: what changed? 2. Why: what drove it? 3. Risk: what could derail us? 4. Decision: what do I recommend? 5. Ask: what do I need from the room?

CHECK

11 READY-FOR-DIRECTOR CHECKLIST

You do not need every box ticked. You should, however, be able to point to evidence for most of them.

- [ ] I can explain the business model and where marketing creates value.
- [ ] I can make trade-offs and say no to work that does not support the strategy.
- [ ] I can defend a budget using commercial logic.
- [ ] I can challenge senior stakeholders without becoming defensive or political.
- [ ] I can coach and delegate instead of personally rescuing every task.
- [ ] I can explain performance in a way the board understands.
- [ ] I have at least three strong leadership case studies.
- [ ] I have a clear view on brand as well as demand generation.
- [ ] I can describe the marketing strategy on one page.
- [ ] I know what kind of Marketing Director role I actually want.

USE THE GAPS

Any boxes that are difficult to tick are useful. They show you where to focus next, rather than leaving career development as a vague ambition.

NEXT

WHAT WILL YOU DO WITH THIS?

Choose one gap, one conversation and one piece of evidence to build this week. Progress comes from using the ideas in your role, not from collecting another document.

MARKETING LEADERSHIP PROGRAMME

SEVEN WEEKS TO STRONGER LEADERSHIP

A live programme for marketers moving towards Head of Marketing, Marketing Director and CMO-level responsibility. It focuses on commercial thinking, strategic judgement, leadership, influence and the practical realities of leading a marketing function.

EXPLORE THE PROGRAMME

francesandkevin.co.uk/marketing-course-for-professionals/

YOUR NEXT THREE ACTIONS

One gap I will work on:

One conversation I will have:

One piece of evidence I will build:



ABOUT FRANCES & KEVIN

PRACTICAL DEVELOPMENT FOR MARKETERS WHO WANT TO LEAD

Frances & Kevin provides live, practical professional development for marketers who want to progress, lead and make a stronger commercial contribution. The emphasis is on real decisions, real work and skills that hold up outside the classroom.

The Marketing Leadership Programme is led by James McCracken FCIM, a practising fractional CMO and Fellow of the Chartered Institute of Marketing.

KEEP THE PLAYBOOK. REVISIT IT IN 90 DAYS.

Look for better evidence, clearer judgement and stronger commercial conversations. Those are the signs that your leadership is moving forward.

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Marketing courses, leadership development and practical professional training

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